

CHAPTER 29 — The Mirror

Sunday began with a problem Zoe had not expected.

Nothing useful was open.

Petrol stations were open.

Supermarkets were open.

A garden centre advertised breakfast until eleven.

But the places that answered questions about old companies and old paperwork had apparently decided organised crime could wait until Monday.

Zoe stood beside the beige estate outside a retail park and looked at the dark windows of an office-supply store.

"This country shuts down whenever we need stationery."

Elias locked the car.

"You have three notebooks."

"Two."

"Three."

"The small one doesn't count."

"It contains writing."

"It contains bus times."

"Still a notebook."

Zoe started towards the supermarket.

"I need coloured tabs."

"For?"

"The mirror."

Elias looked at her.

"That explanation clarified nothing."

"Good."

Inside, Zoe bought sticky tabs, two pens, a ruler, a pack of index cards and chocolate biscuits.

Elias looked into the basket.

"The biscuits are operational?"

"Morale."

"That is not the same thing."

"It is if morale is low."

He added batteries.

Zoe looked at them.

"Operational?"

"Yes."

"Boring."

They paid cash.

Outside, rain had not started yet.

That felt suspicious.

* * *

The garden-centre cafe had artificial waterfalls, discounted patio furniture and an elderly couple quietly disagreeing about hydrangeas.

Zoe ate toast.

Elias drank coffee.

Again.

Always coffee.

She put three index cards on the table.

On the first she wrote:

ASK

On the second:

WATCH

On the third:

DON'T GUESS

Elias looked at them.

"Better."

"Than what?"

"Nothing."

"Good answer."

She put a blue tab on ASK because she had bought blue tabs and intended to use them.

"What do we ask?"

"One narrow thing."

"Adult-facing."

"Preferably."

"No child name."

"Correct."

"No current address."

"Correct."

"No medical."

"Correct."

"No accusation."

Elias lifted his coffee.

"You have remembered the rule."

"I wrote the rule."

"You wrote several rules."

"Because adults keep needing them."

He let that pass.

Zoe opened the intermediary sheet from Voss and Vale.

Payment intermediary.

Communications intermediary.

Vehicle supplier.

Document certifier.

Two addresses.

Three companies.

One company appeared twice.

Meridian Placement Services Ltd.

It sat above a transfer certification in Zoe's folder.

It also appeared in Voss and Vale's old paperwork as a document processor and, later, as the commissioning route for at least one recovery that no longer looked legitimate.

But Meridian did not appear plainly by name in the visible index on the drive.

Only codes did.

Zoe tapped the company name.

"Meridian."

Elias did not immediately agree.

“Why?”

“Because it touches paperwork.”

“That isn’t enough.”

“It appears in my folder.”

“Yes.”

“And in Voss’s jobs.”

“Yes.”

“So it connects two parts without needing my name.”

Elias looked at the sheet.

“What would you ask?”

Zoe thought.

Not whether Meridian trafficked children.

Not whether Zoe’s adoption was fake.

Not what BRG meant.

Something small.

Something an ordinary company should be able to answer without caring who asked.

“Whether one of their documents is actually theirs.”

Elias looked up.

“Which one?”

“Not mine.”

“Good.”

“One Voss already has.”

“Why?”

"Because if Meridian reacts, he can see things we can't."

That survived.

Elias sat back.

"Then we need a document reference that doesn't identify a child."

"And a way to ask them."

"And a way to know whether their answer is unusual."

Zoe frowned. "How?"

"We compare it with something known to be ordinary."

She reached for a biscuit and stopped. "Voss might have one."

"He might."

She pushed the biscuit onto Elias's saucer. "Bribe."

"I don't take bribes."

"Everyone says that before the biscuit."

He ate it. "Corruption."

"Continue."

* * *

Contacting Voss and Vale was the first problem. They had no standing line. That had been intentional.

Reyes's phone was gone.

The active contractor channels had been killed.

The intermediary sheet mapped places where contact had once happened, but Zoe did not want any of those.

"Can they find us?" she asked.

"If we make enough noise."

"That defeats the point."

"Usually."

"Can we find them?"

"Possibly."

"You hate that word."

"I use it accurately."

"Still hate it."

Elias looked through the cafe window.

Rain had finally started.

"Voss kept one passive watch channel."

"He told us?"

"He implied it."

"When?"

"After Clock Square."

Zoe thought back.

"He said he'd know if Mac tried to revive contractor traffic."

"Which means he's watching something."

"Yes."

"Can we put something into it?"

"Not from here."

"Then somewhere else."

Elias watched her.

"You're about to turn an old contractor channel into a message board."

"Not a message board."

"What would you send?"

She already knew what she wanted.

Not a sentence.

Not a location.

Not a name.

One fragment they would recognise.

Then a time.

"MPS-17."

Elias said nothing.

"Then fourteen hundred."

"Too ambiguous."

"Good."

"He might ignore it."

"Then we learn something."

"This is not a test of Voss."

"It can tell us something about him without being the reason we do it."

That was different enough that Elias considered it.

"What does he gain?"

"Nothing."

"What could he sell?"

"A company name he already knows."

"What could he expose?"

"That somebody is checking an old document."

"And if he tells Mac?"

"Mac might react."

Elias looked at her.

Zoe held his gaze.

“That’s the mirror.”

He did not agree immediately.

Good.

Agreement that came too easily was not worth much anymore.

Finally he said, “We use a location we do not reuse.”

“Fine.”

“A route that cannot lead back to the hotel.”

“Fine.”

“We send nothing except the fragment and time.”

“Fine.”

“And if I say move -”

“I move.”

The emergency rule.

No argument first.

Explanation once they were moving.

Elias finished his coffee.

The biscuit was gone.

Bribe successful.

* * *

At eleven thirteen, Voss’s passive handset vibrated once.

Vale looked up from the floor.

They had spent the morning dividing old assignments into three piles:

verified legitimate;

authority uncertain;

authority disproved.

The third pile was no longer small.

Voss picked up the handset.

No greeting.

No name.

Only:

MPS-17

Then:

14:00

Vale stood.

"That them?"

"Likely."

"Elias?"

"Could be."

"Zoe?"

Voss looked at her.

"Could be."

Vale took the handset.

"MPS."

"Meridian Placement Services."

"Seventeen?"

"A reference family we gave them."

"Two o'clock?"

"Probably when something happens."

"No meeting place."

"No."

Vale looked at the old files.

MPS-17 appeared on one document-certification sheet from six years earlier.

A child recovery case.

Temporary placement, later transfer.

No child name on the certificate itself.

Only the document reference.

She found it.

MPS-17-4408

Certification:

AUTHENTICATED COPY

Authority:

Meridian Placement Services Ltd.

Vale read it again.

"They want us watching."

"Probably."

"Could have said that."

"Then anyone reading the message would know."

"Still irritating."

She reached for another file.

“Do we have a Meridian reference we know is clean?”

Voss looked at her.

“If they’re testing one, we need something normal beside it.”

He nodded.

Now the test belonged to more than one person.

* * *

Zoe and Elias spent the next two hours nowhere useful.

That was the point.

Bus.

Shopping centre.

Walk.

Bookshop.

Zoe bought a second-hand fantasy novel because the dragon on the cover looked offended.

Elias bought nothing.

They ate sandwiches beneath an awning while rain came sideways.

At one thirty, Zoe checked the time.

“You think he got it?”

“Yes.”

“Understood it?”

“Probably.”

“If he didn’t?”

“Then ambiguity has limits.”

“Annoyingly reasonable.”

At one forty-five they entered a public library in a different town.

Different building.

Different network.

The archive laptop stayed in the car.

Zoe used a public computer.

The Meridian website looked exactly as a company named Meridian Placement Services should look.

White background.

Blue logo.

Smiling adults around meeting tables.

PLACEMENT SUPPORT

DOCUMENT SERVICES

CASE ADMINISTRATION

COMPLIANCE

No children on the homepage.

Nothing visibly strange.

The company had a public verification form.

Reference number.

Document type.

Date.

Requestor category.

Return email. Zoe worked through the fields slowly.

“It doesn’t ask for a child’s name.”

Elias checked the rest.

“Or a case name.”

“Good.”

They had chosen the reference Voss already possessed.

MPS-17-4408

Authenticated-copy certification.

No child identifier.

No address.

At one fifty-eight, Zoe opened a fresh notebook page.

She wrote the question in ordinary words first:

**Does Meridian confirm MPS-17-4408 as an
authenticated-copy reference?**

No allegation.

No explanation.

No hint that they possessed anything else.

The return address belonged to a fresh account created for this one purpose.

At two exactly, Zoe submitted it.

Closed the browser.

Logged out.

Stood.

“Done.”

Elias said, “Move.”

She moved.

No argument.

They left by the front entrance, turned right, crossed at the lights, entered a pharmacy and left through the other side into a service lane.

No one followed.

At the beige estate, Elias unlocked the car only when they were close.

He drove.

Three turns later:

"Nothing obvious."

Zoe looked at him.

"Explanation delivered."

"Yes."

"Good."

She put a yellow tab on WATCH.

Nothing to write under it yet.

* * *

At two oh four, Meridian answered.

Four minutes.

The reply was automated.

REFERENCE RECEIVED

STATUS: UNDER REVIEW

Zoe saw it twenty minutes later from another public terminal.

She copied the time.

"Too quick for someone to find an old paper file."

"Probably automated intake."

"So it tells us nothing yet."

"Correct."

She did not like that.

She accepted it anyway.

At two twelve, Voss called Meridian.

Not using the number printed on the suspicious certificate.

The public switchboard.

He gave a different reference first.

A known legitimate adult-protection job from five years earlier.

MPS-09-2281

The receptionist transferred him.

A records clerk answered.

Voss asked whether Meridian had issued the reference.

Typing.

Then:

"Yes. Archived certification. Would you like written confirmation?"

"No, thank you."

"How did you obtain the reference?"

"Historic file review."

"Okay."

No pause.

No compliance.

No demand for his identity.

No attempt to find out why he cared.

The call lasted about ninety seconds.

Vale wrote:

CONTROL - NORMAL

At two sixteen, Voss called again from a different public phone.

Same question.

Different reference.

MPS-17-4408

The clerk typed.

Then stopped.

"Can you repeat that?"

Voss did.

More typing.

"Hold, please."

Vale watched the clock.

Twenty seconds.

Forty.

A minute.

The clerk returned.

"I'm sorry. That record is not available through general verification."

"Does that mean it is not authentic?"

"I didn't say that."

"Can you confirm whether Meridian issued it?"

"I'll need your name."

"Why?"

"For the referral."

"What referral?"

"Compliance."

Vale wrote:

DIFFERENT PATH

Voss kept his voice flat.

"I only need yes or no."

"I can't provide that."

"Can written confirmation be sent?"

"Once compliance review is complete."

"How long?"

"I don't know."

"Why does this reference require compliance when MPS-09-2281 did not?"

Silence.

Brief.

Still noticeable.

"You'll need to speak to compliance."

"Put me through."

Hold music.

Then the line disconnected.

Vale looked at the phone.

"Accident?"

"No."

"Call back?"

"No."

"Why?"

"Because now we watch."

She hated waiting.

Which was probably why it was correct.

* * *

At two thirty-eight, Mac's solicitor received a notification.

It did not say Zoe.

It did not say Elias.

It did not say Voss.

It said:

LEGACY CERTIFICATION QUERY

MPS-17-4408

EXTERNAL VALIDATION ATTEMPT

He checked it again.

Then called Meridian.

The head of compliance answered personally.

That was the first bad sign.

"Who asked?"

"Two channels."

"Two?"

"Public form and telephone."

"Same requester?"

"Unknown."

"What information did they give?"

"Reference only."

"Any name?"

"No." "Any child identifier?" "No." "Placement address?" "No." "Then why did it flag?" A pause. "Restricted certification family." The solicitor stopped writing. "Who else received the alert?" "Automatic distribution." "To whom?" Another pause. "How many?" "Three." "Names." "I can't provide that over -" "Names."

The compliance officer gave two organisations and one private office.

The second organisation belonged to Cain's side of the machinery.

The private office belonged to Mac.

The first belonged to neither.

That was worse.

"Do not contact anyone else."

"It's automatic."

"Turn it off."

"I can't."

"Then find someone who can."

He ended the call.

One old reference had been touched from outside.

The alert had gone three ways before anyone knew who was asking or why.

Whatever the restricted family protected, it had been built on the assumption that several people needed warning the moment somebody looked at it.

* * *

At two fifty-one, Vale's passive handset vibrated.

Not the one Zoe had touched.

Another old contractor route.

A message from an intermediary they had not heard from since Reyes died.

ARCHIVE RECONCILIATION IN EFFECT

HISTORIC CERTIFICATION MATERIAL - DO NOT

RELEASE

DIRECT ALL EXTERNAL REQUESTS TO COMPLIANCE

Vale read it aloud.

Voss looked at the clock.

Thirty-five minutes after the suspicious call.

“One reference and they’re warning old contractors not to release paperwork.”

“Yes.”

“That’s bigger than Meridian’s records desk.”

“Yes.”

Vale looked at him.

“So they’re hiding something.”

“Maybe.”

She gave him a look.

“The query changed behaviour,” Voss said. “That is what we know.”

Vale stared at the warning again.

Do not release.

Not denial.

Containment.

Different thing.

"Send nothing back," Voss said.

She had already decided the same.

If they replied, they became part of the reaction.

For once, they would stay still and watch somebody else move.

* * *

At three twenty, Zoe received Meridian's second response.

Not at the first library.

They had moved again.

A small internet cafe near a bus station.

The message read:

Your request has been referred for compliance review.

**Please provide your full name, organisation, contact
number and reason for request.**

Zoe read it once.

Then again.

"That's not an answer."

"No."

"They want to know who asked before they say whether the document is theirs."

"Correct."

She wrote under WATCH:

asks who we are instead of answering

Then:

no reply

At three forty-seven, Elias's temporary handset received a message through the passive route Voss had used after Clock Square.

Three lines.

CONTROL CLEARED NORMALLY.

TEST FLAGGED.

CHANNEL WARNING ISSUED.

No case information.

No names.

No request to meet. Zoe lingered on it.

The handset had been bought that morning.

One expected incoming route.

No archive data.

No location.

No names.

It would not survive the day.

She wrote the two references side by side:

MPS-09-2281

MPS-17-4408

Below them:

same company

same kind of question

different behaviour

Elias watched.

"Does that prove Meridian is criminal?"

"No."

"Does it prove the document is forged?"

"No."

"What does it prove?"

Zoe tapped the suspicious number. "They treat this one differently."

"And?"

"It triggers compliance."

"And?"

"Old contractor traffic changed."

She stopped there. Elias did not fill the silence. Zoe looked at the two references again. "Something about this family is watched."

"Strongly supported."

"Why?"

"We don't know."

She wrote:

DON'T GUESS

Then beneath it:

**restricted reference causes wider reaction. don't know
why yet.**

She left it at that.

The mirror was not giving them an answer.

It was giving them shape.

* * *

Cain received his warning at four twelve.

Not from Meridian.

From someone who had received it from someone else.

That was how Cain preferred information.

No direct link when three indirect ones would do.

The call lasted thirty seconds.

Historic certification query.

Restricted family.

External unknown.

No child identifier.

No known source.

Cain stood in the kitchen of a house Zoe had never seen.

The house was empty except for him and one man at the table.

The man had a bruise along his jaw and a phone placed screen-down beside one hand.

Cain listened.

Then asked one question.

"Which family?"

The caller gave the code.

MPS-17.

Cain looked at the man.

The man did not look back.

"Clear the paper store."

"How much?"

"All restricted certification copies."

"That will take -"

"Today."

"Where?"

"Secondary."

Cain ended the call.

The man at the table said, "That's a lot of movement for one query."

Cain looked at him.

"Yes."

"Could be police."

"Yes."

"Could be Mac."

Cain's expression changed by almost nothing.

The man saw it.

"Why would Mac ask?"

The man shrugged.

"Maybe he doesn't trust what he bought."

Cain stared at the phone.

Mac had already created problems.

The failed recovery.

The outside contractor team.

The dead man.

The public meeting.

The loss of the archive.

Now someone had touched a restricted certification family.

No child number.

No archive reference.

Just paperwork.

Cain disliked coincidences.

He disliked Mac more.

“Clear it,” he repeated.

The man stood.

Cain added:

“And find out who received the first alert.”

Not who asked.

Who received.

The network was built on compartments.

If something had started leaking, the people who became nervous first might show him where.

* * *

At four thirty, Mac learned Cain’s people had started moving archive boxes.

He had not ordered it.

That was the point.

His solicitor called.

“Secondary paper store is active.”

“Why?”

“Cain.”

“On whose instruction?”

"Unknown."

Mac stood in his study.

Books.

Desk.

Window.

Everything expensive enough to suggest stability.

"Tell him to stop."

"I don't control him."

Mac looked at the wall.

"No. I do." The solicitor said nothing. The silence irritated Mac more than contradiction. "Who queried Meridian?" "Unknown." "Voss?" "Possible." "Elias?" "Possible." "The girl?" The solicitor hesitated. Mac heard it. "Say it." "Possible." Mac laughed once. No humour. "She's thirteen." "So?"

The question landed badly.

Mac turned from the window.

"She does not understand the system."

"She may not need to."

Mac said nothing.

The solicitor continued.

"One reference produced multiple reactions. If someone is comparing them -"

"Enough."

Mac ended the call.

For years complexity had protected him.

No one person knew enough.

No route showed the whole transaction.

No document meant anything without another document stored somewhere else.

No buyer spoke directly to the hidden placement office.

No contractor knew why a recovery mattered.

No recipient knew the origin of the paperwork beyond what Mac chose to explain.

Compartmentalisation turned guilt into fragments. Now the fragments were reacting to one another. That was not supposed to happen. Mac picked up a second phone. Called Cain. Cain answered on the fifth ring. "You're moving material."

"Yes."

"Stop."

"No."

Mac's grip tightened. "You are creating visibility."

"You created visibility."

"Do not confuse your failed recovery with my problem."

Cain was quiet. Then: "Your problem is the reason the archive is gone."

Something old and ugly moved beneath Mac's ribs.

"Reyes went in early."

"Reyes was yours."

"He was an independent contractor."

"Bought by you."

There it was.

Not partnership.

Accounting.

Whose mistake.

Whose dead man.

Whose exposure.

“Do not move anything else,” Mac said.

Cain replied:

“Then stop people asking questions.”

The line went dead.

One document reference had entered the system.

Already two men who needed each other were deciding which failures belonged to whom.

* * *

Zoe knew none of that.

No archive boxes.

No call between Mac and Cain.

No argument over Reyes.

Her mirror had shown her something smaller.

Meridian treated the suspicious reference differently from the known legitimate one.

The suspicious query triggered an instruction through an old contractor channel.

Voss and Vale had received only a fragment.

They had asked for nothing else.

They had run their own control.

Reported the result.

No request for a meeting.

No attempt to obtain the drive.

Zoe wrote:

Voss/Vale didn't ask for more.

Elias read it.

"Useful."

"Trust?"

"Evidence towards it."

She thought about that.

Then wrote:

TRUST = BEHAVIOUR, NOT PROMISES

Elias said nothing.

Better.

"What do we do with Meridian now?"

"Nothing."

"Nothing?"

"We asked."

"They reacted."

"We don't know how far."

"So ask another."

"Not yet."

"Why?"

"One question can look accidental. Five questions tell them somebody is mapping the system."

Zoe stopped.

That made immediate sense.

"Then they start changing things because of us."

"Exactly."

"And we stop seeing what they normally do."

"Exactly."

She put the pen down.

"Fine."

"What next?"

The false order.

Not whether it was false.

Voss had already proved one supposed court order did not exist in the real court system.

The next question was better.

Where had the real information inside it come from?

Case number.

Judge.

Placement.

Review history.

Names.

The hidden layer did not invent everything.

It copied.

Which meant somewhere there might be an original document beside the imitation.

Zoe wrote:

NEXT: FIND WHAT THE FALSE ORDER COPIED

Elias read it.

"That one can stay."

"Permission granted?"

"No."

"Shame."

* * *

They destroyed the temporary phone at dusk.

Not dramatically.

No hammer.

No river.

Elias removed the battery and SIM.

The handset went into an electronics-recycling bin at a supermarket several towns away.

The battery went somewhere else. The SIM somewhere else again. Zoe watched the pieces disappear. "Disappointing."

"What were you expecting?"

"Fire."

"Fire attracts attention."

"Everything fun attracts attention."

"Usually."

They bought dinner. Microwave pasta. Bread. Two yoghurts. Zoe added chocolate mousse. "Morale?" Elias asked.

"Operational necessity."

"Of course."

The beige estate took them west.

No pursuit.

No repeated headlights.

No obvious tail.

At eight ten they checked into a motel beside a motorway service area.

The room had a kettle and a chair shaped as if nobody had ever sat comfortably in it.

The backpack went on Zoe's bed.

The working-copy bag went on the other.

Neither of them opened the drive.

The entire test had used one document reference.

The rest had come from what people did.

Zoe sat cross-legged on the bed.

"So Meridian treats it as restricted."

"Yes."

"We don't know what the document actually changed."

"No."

"Don't know who made it."

"No."

"Don't know who inside Meridian understands the flag."

"No."

"And the normal records person could be completely innocent."

"Yes."

She looked at him.

"That was a lot of no."

"Variety."

"Improvement."

The television news showed football.

Again.

Zoe groaned.

"Does nothing else happen in the world?"

"Frequently."

"Not according to television."

Elias changed channel.

Cooking.

Changed again.

A shark documentary.

Zoe pointed.

"Leave it."

They watched a shark eat something that had made several poor choices.

For twelve minutes nobody discussed corrupted safeguarding systems.

* * *

At nine twenty-six, Voss placed the passive handset inside a metal box and shut the lid.

Vale sat on the floor among the files.

"Do we trust them?"

Voss looked at her.

"Elias?"

"Zoe."

The distinction mattered more now.

"She sent one reference."

"Yes."

"No child."

"No."

"No context."

"No."

"Didn't tell us what answer she wanted."

"No."

Vale nodded. "Better than most clients."

"She is not a client."

"I know."

"Do you?"

Vale looked up. Their professional instincts were dangerous here. Client. Target. Asset. Recovery. Words that turned people into roles. Zoe had already been processed by enough roles. Vale closed the file.

"What are we, then?"

"Useful if we remain useful."

"Bleak."

"Accurate."

She considered it.

"Verification."

"Yes."

"Not protection."

"No."

"Not command."

"No."

"Not forgiveness."

Voss looked at her.

"No."

That one had been for herself.

Reyes remained dead.

The girl in the yellow coat remained somewhere unknown.

Other jobs remained in boxes.

Doing something right now would not rewrite the old pages.

It would only affect the next one.

Vale picked up the false order.

"Tomorrow?"

"Yes."

"Real court. Real record."

"Yes."

"Find the source they copied."

"Yes."

She smiled faintly.

"Zoe's going to get there first."

"Probably."

"Annoying."

"Yes."

* * *

Zoe woke at eleven forty-three because somebody closed a car door outside.

She was upright before she understood why. Dark room. Motorway light through the curtains. Elias awake in the chair. Book open. He looked at her. "Car door."

"I know."

"Anything else?"

She listened. Voices. A suitcase wheel. A child complaining. Zoe went to the curtain and checked for herself. A family unloading luggage. Two children arguing. A father carrying a pillow. Nothing.

She sat back on the bed.

"Fear's still faster than evidence."

"Usually."

Her heart took longer to agree.

Elias did not say safe.

Did not tell her to lie down.

He waited.

Zoe looked at the cards beside her notebook.

ASK.

WATCH.

DON'T GUESS.

The system had reacted because it did not know who had asked.

That uncertainty mattered.

Someone somewhere knew an old Meridian reference had been touched.

They did not know by whom.

They did not know why.

They did not know what else the questioner had.

So they had to decide what to protect.

Every protection choice risked showing what mattered.

Zoe looked towards Elias.

“You know what the mirror actually is?”

He lowered the book.

“What?”

“Not the question.”

“No?”

“The panic.”

Elias waited.

“The question is just light. When they panic, they show you what shape they are.”

He considered it.

“Reaction.”

Zoe sighed.

“You ruin everything.”

“Panic assumes emotion.”

“They’re definitely emotional.”

“Some of them.”

“Fine.”

She corrected herself.

“When they react, they show you what shape they are.”

Elias nodded once.

“Better.”

Zoe lay back down.

The false order was next.

Not to prove it false.

That part was already easy.

They would look for the truth inside it.

The real case it copied.

The real authority it imitated.

The point where something legitimate had been taken apart and rebuilt into paperwork that could move a child while everyone downstream believed they were doing their jobs.

Tonight, though, the first mirror had worked.

One small question had gone into the system.

The system had looked back.